

Mayor’s budget fight hits the road

Heated town hall in foe’s ward signals battle’s next fronts

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson held a South Side town hall Tuesday evening to again hammer the city budget, the latest score-settling between him and the City Council bloc that passed its own plan in December after rejecting key parts of his proposal.

The fiery meeting at the South Shore Cultural Center began with local Ald. Desmon Yancy, a progressive who voted with mayoral opponents, questioning why Johnson was still attacking the budget for allegedly being short \$163 million.

The mayor and his team then broke down their issues with the final spending package, a sign that last fall’s grueling fight shows no signs of simmering down over a month into 2026, even as both sides say the budget could still require midyear changes to make it work.

“If it wasn’t balanced, why wasn’t the veto power used to send it back to the council?” Yancy said. “Pardon the pun. Something isn’t quite adding up.”

The \$16.6 billion budget passed in late December in a historic rebuke of the mayor, averting a government shut-down. Just as unprecedented is the Johnson administration continuing to sound the alarm on a spate of issues it sees with the revenue projections, while his council opposition has complained those arguments are misleading.

All these forces converge to signal continued instability at City Hall in the wake of the political realignment spurred by the council rebellion against Johnson. That could present warning signs to credit rating agencies, portend a just-as-rocky budget cycle for 2027 and — per the mayor’s warnings — lead to layoffs that could hit the Police and Fire departments if fixes don’t come.

“There are forces, make no mistake about it, in this city, who would much rather work

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Minn. leaders demand faster ICE withdrawal

Administration to pull quarter of agents after state agrees to hand over arrested immigrants | About 2K officers will remain, roughly same number as when surge ramped up in January



A federal immigration agent tackles a protester to the ground in Minneapolis on Tuesday. ALEX KORMANN/THE MINNESOTA STAR TRIBUNE

By Steve Karnowski
Associated Press

MINNEAPOLIS — The Trump administration is reducing the number of immigration officers in Minnesota but will continue its enforcement operation that has sparked weeks of tensions and deadly confrontations, border czar Tom Homan said Wednesday.

About 700 federal officers — roughly a quarter of the total deployed to Minnesota — will be withdrawn immediately after state and local officials agreed over the past week to cooperate by turning over arrested immigrants, Homan said.

But he did not provide a timeline for when the administration might end the operation that has become a flashpoint in the debate over President Donald Trump’s mass deportation efforts since the fatal shootings of U.S. citizens Renee Good and Alex Pretti in Minneapolis.



Border czar Tom Homan speaks in Minneapolis on Wednesday after agreeing to pull some agents from the state. JOHN MOORE/GETTY

Deportation blocked for acquitted man

A federal judge in Indiana has temporarily barred federal officials from deporting a Chicago man acquitted last month of charges he offered money for the killing of Border Patrol’s Bovino. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

About 2,000 officers will remain in the state after this week’s draw-down, Homan said. That’s roughly the same number sent to Minnesota in early January when the surge ramped up, kicking off what the Department of Homeland Security called its “largest immigration enforcement operation ever.”

Since then, masked, heavily armed officers have been met by resistance from residents who are upset with their aggressive tactics.

A widespread pullout, Homan said, will occur only after there’s more cooperation and protesters stop interfering with federal agents carrying out arrests.

Trump told NBC News he ordered the reduction, adding that one lesson coming out of the turmoil in Minnesota is “maybe we can use a little bit of a softer touch. But you still have to be tough.”

Gov. Tim Walz and Minneapolis Mayor Jacob Frey, both

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Sympathy, but skepticism, for new mural of slain refugee

By Madeline King
Chicago Tribune

The face of Iryna Zarutska stretches almost the entire height of a three-floor brick building, her blonde hair tucked over her shoulder as she peers at the corner of West Montrose and North Western avenues.

Zarutska, a 23-year-old Ukrainian refugee who was fatally stabbed in North Carolina in an unprovoked attack on a light rail train in August, doesn’t have any apparent connection to North Center — or even Chicago. Most walking past don’t seem to look up.

Yet, the newly painted mural



People walk past a mural of Iryna Zarutska in Chicago’s North Center neighborhood on Jan. 22. JOSH BOLAND/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

over a restaurant is part of a nationwide project by Remember Iryna, which has also overseen installations in New York City, Los Angeles, Miami and Washington, D.C., according to its website.

The killing of Zarutska, who

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ELECTION 2026

County clerk urges early mail-in voting

USPS change makes cutoff harder to hit

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

A little less than six weeks before the March 17 primary election, Democratic Cook County Clerk Monica Gordon urged mail-in voters on Wednesday to return their ballots early amid a change in federal government procedures that she warned could make it harder to vote.

Gordon tied her concerns to the United States Postal Service’s recent decision, effective Jan. 1, to alter postmarking processes.

While postmarks in the past were typically applied on the day an item was mailed, they are now listed as the day an item was processed at a USPS facility.

While the change might appear small, it could mean the difference of a day or more between ballots dropped in the mail and being postmarked, resulting in those mailed near the March 17 deadline not being postmarked by Election Day and therefore deemed invalid, even if a voter does “everything right,” Gordon said during a news conference.

“While this change has been described as minor, its impact on

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